

Case Study: The "Receive Money" QR Scam

The Crime UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a form of digital financial theft where scammers exploit the "push" nature of real-time payments to trick victims into authorizing unauthorized debits. Unlike traditional banking, which may have a "cooling period," UPI transactions are instant and irreversible once the sender enters their secret PIN.

How it Happens (Step-by-Step)

1. **Target Selection:** A fraudster scans online marketplaces (like OLX or Facebook Marketplace) for individuals selling high-value items like furniture or electronics.
2. **Contact & Trust Building:** The scammer contacts the seller, posing as an eager buyer. They often claim to be an army officer or a busy professional to build immediate trust and explain why they cannot visit in person.
3. **The "Test" Transaction:** To "verify" the seller's account, the scammer sends a small payment (e.g., ₹1) to show they are legitimate.
4. **The Trap:** The scammer then sends a **QR code** via WhatsApp, claiming the seller needs to "scan it to receive the remaining balance."
5. **Authorization:** When the victim scans the code, their UPI app prompts them to **enter their PIN**. The victim, believing they are receiving money, enters the PIN, which actually authorizes a **debit** from their account.

Who is Targeted? While anyone can be a target, scammers frequently zero in on small-scale online sellers, senior citizens unfamiliar with digital payment logic, and students looking for quick transactions.

Consequences: Victims often face immediate financial loss, ranging from a few thousand to several lakhs of rupees. In a **2025 incident reported in Jaipur**, a street vendor lost ₹8,500—his entire week's earnings—after scanning a malicious "payment" QR code. Beyond financial strain, victims experience significant psychological distress and a long, often unsuccessful, recovery process through cybercrime cells (Helpline 1930).

Source: Analysis based on RBI 2024-25 Annual Report data and documented cases from the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (2025-2026).